

In new jolt, Mexico and Canada get a reprieve

One-month tariff pause follows auto industry carve-out a day earlier

BY ABHA BHATTARAI, MARY BETH SHERIDAN AND AMANDA COLETTA

MEXICO CITY — President Donald Trump on Thursday postponed for another month imposing tariffs on certain Mexican and Canadian products that comply with the North American free-trade treaty — the latest swerve in the roller coaster of U.S. trade relations roiling financial markets for a third straight day.

Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum said she persuaded Trump to push off the penalties in a phone call Thursday morning. Trump had threatened in early February to impose 25 percent tariffs on all Mexican and Canadian goods, citing what he called the countries’ failure to stem illegal migration and fentanyl trafficking, but he delayed them for a month as the countries scrambled to strengthen border security. They took effect Tuesday.

The pause on tariffs applies only to imports that comply with the free-trade agreement between the United States, Canada and Mexico signed during Trump’s first term. About 50 percent of goods from Mexico and 62 percent from Canada, including computers, will still face the tariffs implemented this week, a White House official said Thursday. Canadian energy and potash, a key component of fertilizer, will

SEE TARIFFS ON A14

Europe scrambles to bolster its defenses

E.U. countries move to raise military spending as Trump shifts alliances

BY ELLEN FRANCIS AND BEATRIZ RÍOS

BRUSSELS — The European Union’s leaders made a rallying cry Thursday to embark on a military buildup to a degree they haven’t done in decades, as they contend with the specter of rising Russian belligerence and faltering U.S. support.

Along with Russia’s war in Ukraine, President Donald Trump’s sudden redrawing of alliances and withdrawal of support for Kyiv are driving Europeans to fast-track plans to bolster their militaries, upgrade their arsenals — and, ultimately, to curb their dependence on the United States.

E.U. leaders broadly agreed to move forward with plans intended to unlock hundreds of billions in extra defense spending in the coming years, but a military spending spree won’t be easy. Meanwhile, Germany is starting a big shift away from controls

SEE EUROPE ON A12

Starlink: Ukraine fears Musk may cut the vital internet service. **A12**



JOSE LUIS GONZALEZ/REUTERS

Cattle set to be exported to the United States are seen Tuesday at the Chihuahua Regional Livestock Union, in Nuevo Palomas, Mexico.

Musk targets sensitive trove of workers’ earnings

BY JEFF STEIN AND DAN DIAMOND

Representatives of the U.S. DOGE Service have sought access to a powerful database of nearly all U.S. workers’ earnings kept by the health department’s child support office, setting off another disagreement with career staff over demands for legally protected records, according to four people familiar with the matter.

Over the last several weeks, billionaire Elon Musk’s DOGE team has clashed with civil servants over attempts to access privileged information or systems kept by the Treasury Department, IRS and Social Security Administration, among other agencies.

Earlier this week, however, associates with DOGE, the Department of Government Efficiency, targeted what several ex-

DOGE’s attempt to probe child support database provokes another clash

perts and government officials described as perhaps the most sensitive of all — a system within a broader government database created to help enforce child support payments, which pulls a vast trove of information, including income data linked to nearly all workers. People familiar with the situation spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss internal debates.

It wasn’t immediately clear why DOGE sought the health agency’s database. But Musk’s team has expressed interest in recent days in checking personal tax records against federal ben-

efits, grants and student loans — a measure that could enable it to link together traditionally siloed government systems to search for duplicative or wasteful payments.

The database kept at the Department of Health and Human Services is part of a system known as the Federal Parent Locator Service. DOGE was particularly interested in accessing a component known as the National Directory of New Hires, which draws on several data streams, said one of the people who spoke with The Washington Post. One data stream includes information about all new employees across the country; a second data stream includes quarterly wage data; and a third data stream includes information about unemployment insurance benefits. The data, which is reported by employers and state agencies,

encompasses nearly all U.S. workers, the person said.

DOGE officials were rebuffed by a career civil servant, who questioned the group’s authority, two people said.

It wasn’t immediately clear whether DOGE had accessed the system. Spokespeople for the White House and HHS did not immediately respond to requests for comment.

The database was created in 1996 to help parents with custody of their children and the government withhold regular child support payments from the income of parents without custody.

SEE DOGE ON A15

Foreign aid cuts: Christian charity groups are feeling the sting. **A4**

Spy agency layoffs: Impact feared on espionage, job recruiting. **A15**

Analytics has reshaped sports — but at what cost?

As the quest for efficiency leads to what many consider poor aesthetics, leagues seek solutions

BY DAVE SHEININ

At the end of a Jan. 23 news conference in Paris, where even the NBA’s global ambitions failed to shield him from domestic criticism over the state of the league’s product, Commissioner Adam Silver acknowledged something that many had concluded long ago: The NBA’s analytics movement had pushed the game to a problematic place — one that sits exactly 23 feet 9 inches from the goal or 22 feet in the corners — where the league must now consider intervening.

When it comes to the NBA’s glut of three-pointers, Silver said, “it’s absolutely [true] that the analytics have taken teams in certain directions.” Coaches and general managers paid to win at all costs, he said, are “not necessarily focused on the aesthetic appeal of the game.” He concluded: “I’m listening to the critics. I don’t want to overreact, but I think there potentially are some adjustments we can make.”

Change the setting and the sport-centered specifics, move the date back five or six years, and those same words could



ILLUSTRATION BY DAVIDE BONAZZI FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

have been spoken by MLB Commissioner Rob Manfred. In fact, they essentially were.

“The changes you’re seeing [on the field] are being driven by smart [team personnel] who want to win more baseball

games,” Manfred said before the 2018 All-Star Game, addressing criticism of baseball’s on-field product. “The question [is]: At what point do we want to step in and manage that organic change?”

The analytics movement ar-

guably has transformed the major sports landscape like no development since the dawn of televised games, changing the way coaches coach, players play, front offices evaluate talent and fans consume the

SEE ANALYTICS ON A8

IN THE NEWS

Fluttering away Butterfly populations across the contiguous U.S. decreased by 22 percent from 2000 to 2020, a new study revealed. **A16**

D.C. hastens camp removal A notice from President Donald Trump sped up the city’s plans to clear out a homeless encampment near the State Department. **B1**

THE NATION **More state colleges** are using “direct admissions” to accept students before they apply. **A3** **A law firm** that represented Trump’s political rivals was targeted in an executive order. **A4**

THE WORLD **South Korean fighter jets** mistakenly bombed a village north of Seoul, injuring 15. **A10** **The U.S.** has proposed an extension to the Gaza ceasefire in exchange for hostages’ release. **A11**

THE ECONOMY **Republicans** still have to make cuts before they can finalize their “big, beautiful bill” on the president’s agenda. **A13** **SpaceX**, the parent company of Starlink, confirmed working with the FAA but denied reports it’s taking over a Verizon contract. **A15**

THE REGION **Cedric T. Wins**, the outgoing superintendent of VMI, cited “bias” and “ideology” for his contract not being renewed. **B1** **The D.C.** housing agency is negotiating after being ordered to fix violations against people with disabilities. **B1**

STYLE **“Hamilton”** canceled its upcoming Kennedy Center shows, citing Trump’s recent takeover of the venue. **C1**

WEEKEND **Looking** for the best soup in D.C.? Here are eight favorites. The great ones aren’t fancy; they just get it right.

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